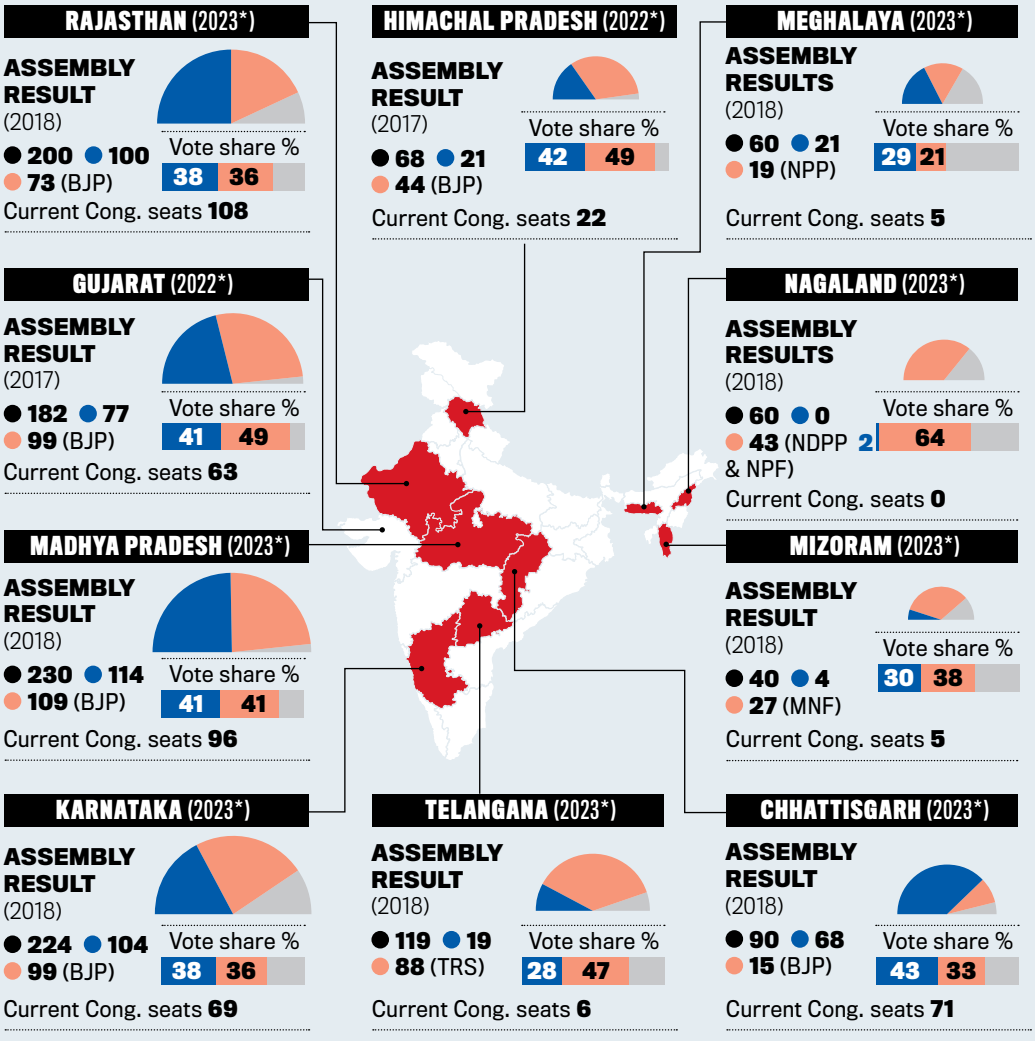
# FUTURE TENSE

**The 10 states going to polls in the next two years account for 144 Lok Sabha seats, of which the Congress won just nine in 2019 even though it won assembly elections in three of them. In the last assembly polls, it won 502 or 39 per cent of the 1,273 seats in these 10 states. The number has now come down to 445, mostly because of defections.**

- Total seats
- Seats Congress won in previous election
- Seats won by its primary rival
- Other parties

*Year in which state poll is scheduled




hoc and reactive at best. It first batted for soft Hindutva, what with Rahul declaring himself a *janeudhari* Shiv *bhakt* and engaged in a spot of temple-hopping. When that failed to cut any ice, as it was bound to, the Congress changed tack saying it was for Hinduism and not Hindutva, a binary largely lost on the electorate.

Nor has the Congress been able to build any convincing economic narrative. The much-touted Nyay or Nyuntam Aay Yojana, a minimum income guarantee scheme, hardly got any traction in 2019. Inflation and unemployment have been credible issues, but they have not yet succeeded in denting the popularity of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. "We had been protesting in front of the Raj Bhavan in Jharkhand against the price rise," says Avinash Pandey, member of the Congress Working Committee and the Jharkhand in-charge. "Though people are suffering because of inflation, people around the protest site looked at us in a way that made us feel like fools wasting time on random issues. Hijab, halal and loudspeakers seem more important issues."

**ON PAPER, ALL ITS COMMITTEES ARE IN PLACE. WHAT'S LACKING IS A SYSTEM OF ACCOUNTABILITY**

The Congress used to draw its strength from a rainbow vote bank of multiple castes and communities such as Dalits, OBCs and Muslims. Since the 1990s or the post-Mandal era, it has gradually been ceding its support base to caste- and state-based regional forces such as the Samajwadi Party in UP, the Rashtriya Janata Dal in Bihar, the TMC in Bengal, and to Muslim parties such the AIMIM and AIUDF. Post